

Wine Aroma Guide

Primary Aromas by Wine Style & Grape

WHITE WINES		
Category	Aromas	Key Grapes
Floral	Chamomile, acacia, honeysuckle, jasmine	<i>Viognier, Gewurztraminer, Riesling</i>
Green Fruits	Green apple, pear, pear drop, quince	<i>Sauvignon Blanc, Chablis Chardonnay, Pinot Grigio</i>
Citrus	Lemon, lime, zest, grapefruit, orange peel — signals higher acidity	<i>Riesling, Albariño, Sauvignon Blanc</i>
Stone Fruit	Apricot, peach, nectarine	<i>Viognier, Roussanne, warm climate Chardonnay</i>
Tropical Fruits	Mango, pineapple, passionfruit, lychee, melon	<i>Gewurztraminer, Marlborough Sauvignon Blanc, oaked Chardonnay</i>
Dried/Cooked Fruits	Fig, apricot jam, preserved citrus, honey	<i>Late harvest Riesling, Sauternes, aged Chenin Blanc</i>
Herbaceous	Grass, tomato leaf, asparagus	<i>Sauvignon Blanc, Grüner Veltliner</i>
Herbs	Fennel, mint, dill, rosemary	<i>Vermentino, Grüner Veltliner, Assyrtiko</i>
Spice	White pepper, ginger, anise	<i>Grüner Veltliner, Gewurztraminer, Chenin Blanc</i>
Earth / Mineral	Flint, wet stones, chalk, saline	<i>Chablis, Sancerre, Assyrtiko, Albariño</i>

ROSÉ WINES		
Category	Aromas	Key Grapes
Floral	Rose petal, violet, hibiscus	<i>Grenache rosé, Pinot Noir rosé</i>
Citrus	Grapefruit, blood orange, lemon zest	<i>Syrah rosé, Mourvèdre rosé</i>
Red Fruits	Strawberry, raspberry, red cherry, watermelon	<i>Grenache, Pinot Noir, Sangiovese rosé</i>
Stone Fruit	White peach, nectarine	<i>Provence style, Grenache/Cinsault blends</i>
Herbs	Lavender, dried herbs, garrigue	<i>Provence rosé, Southern Rhône blends</i>
Earth/Mineral	Wet stones, saline, chalk	<i>Provence rosé, Tavel</i>

RED WINES		
Category	Aromas	Key Grapes
Floral	Violet, rose, dried flowers	<i>Syrah, Nebbiolo, Malbec, Petit Verdot</i>
Red Fruits	Red cherry, raspberry, strawberry, red currant, red plum	<i>Pinot Noir, Grenache, Sangiovese, cool climate Merlot</i>

Dark Fruits	Black cherry, blackberry, blackcurrant, black plum, blueberry	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon, Syrah, Mourvèdre, Zinfandel</i>
Dried/Cooked Fruits	Prune, raisin, fig, dried cherry, sultana	<i>Amarone, Zinfandel, hot climate Grenache, Malbec</i>
Herbaceous	Green pepper, tomato leaf, asparagus	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon, Carménère, Cabernet Franc</i>
Herbs	Lavender, rosemary, mint, fennel, garrigue	<i>Grenache, Southern Rhône blends, Mourvèdre</i>
Spice	Black pepper, white pepper, licorice, clove	<i>Syrah, Grenache, Zinfandel, Tempranillo</i>
Earth / Mineral	Wet earth, forest floor, iron, volcanic ash	<i>Pinot Noir, Nebbiolo, Sangiovese, Assyrtiko</i>
Dried / Savoury	Leather, tobacco, meat, game, mushroom, truffle	<i>Aged Nebbiolo, Tempranillo, Pinot Noir, Mourvèdre</i>

Tertiary Aromas in Red Wines

The Dried/Savoury row at the bottom of the red wine table (leather, tobacco, mushroom, truffle) is technically tertiary — these aromas develop through aging in oak or bottle, not from the grape itself. This is why a young Barolo smells very different from one aged 10+ years.

Herbaceous Aromas Are Primary

Herbaceous notes in red wines (green pepper, tomato leaf, asparagus) are primary aromas — they come from pyrazine compounds found naturally in the grape skin. They are most prominent in cooler climates or in less ripe vintages, which is why a Napa Cabernet shows less green pepper than one from Bordeaux.